Two years later, when Shuja announced his intention of joining Wa'fa Begum, 'from affection for our August Consort and a desire to see our friends, the illustrious English', Ochterlony's mix of generosity and strategic foresight again trumped Metcalfe's caution, and he was allowed to send his assistant, William Fraser, to welcome him at the border.[23]

Fraser was quick to note the great changes that had taken place in the Shah since their last meeting in Peshawar. Seven years of defeat, betrayal, humiliation, torture and imprisonment had taken their toll, and it was clear that Shuja had become damaged, difficult and depressive. He was also almost pathologically determined to ensure that the façade of his royal status should be maintained despite the reality that he was now no more than what Ochterlony called 'an illustrious fugitive' – a refugee dependent on the charity of his former allies. But if Fraser had expected a broken man, he was to be surprised. 'The Shah arrived at the frontier yesterday,' he wrote to Ochterlony. 'I am sorry to learn that he is very Ultra-Royal in his wishes and expectations. He summoned your Munshi and told him he expected that the people of the country should keep at the distance of half a coss from his person, which was a customary observance towards Majesty.' Like the last Mughals, having lost an empire, his court became the focus of his ambitions, and the more powerless he became the more he insisted on public acknowledgement of his royal status. Yet for all the pretension, the reality of his situation was desperate:

> He has not fifty armed attendants and is greatly changed since I saw him last, having greatly increased in bulk and acquired a heavy, almost inanimate look. He has already been abandoned by most of those who arrived with him, and of the few attendants left, I did not recognise one who was of any note during the Kabul mission, nor one indeed whom I had seen before. The scene to me was a painful one. The reverse of fortune is nothing, but the ingratitude and abandonment which seem its consequence are indeed a sorry sight. The former is what all may expect and all should have, but the desolating nature of the latter might shake to its foundation the finest philosophy.[24]

Shuja arrived in Ludhiana at the end of September 1816, nearly two years after his wives. From the beginning he made it clear that the accommodation arranged for him was inadequate for his needs. He demanded as a king and an ally bound by treaty that the British provide him with more than just asylum and a pension: he should have a decent house with walls sufficiently high that his women could be secluded without being